

On the charge: Aizawl's 23-year-old striker, Lalrinzuala Lalbiaknia, recently scored 15 goals in 20 matches, breaking a decade-old joint record of Chhetri and Rafi of most goals by an Indian in an I-League season. AIFF MEDIA

"For an Indian striker, it's difficult to get a chance to play. Every team has overseas strikers and it is hard for an Indian to get into the team," Jeje had told in an interview with *Goal*.

This season, Indians who started as strikers have scored just nine goals while that number for foreigners is a staggering 98. Kerala Blasters' Dimitrios Diamantakos (**below**; 13 goals) alone has scored more than all Indians combined.

This might just be the reason that nine of the 12 clubs have chosen to play only foreign strikers in 3/4th of their matches while three clubs — Odisha FC, Punjab FC and FC Goa — have not started an Indian striker at all throughout the season. Two of the three have qualified for the playoffs.

It is also interesting to note the names of the three clubs that have chosen to swim against the current — Bengaluru FC, Hyderabad FC and Chennaiyin FC.

Bengaluru FC had 16 of its 19 matches with Chhetri as one of its strikers. Without Chhetri in the



equation, the number drops from 16 to just three — a fall of 69%, which only embellishes the mammoth impact the Indian skipper has had, both in terms of consistency and performance.

Hyderabad FC, a club embroiled in financial turmoil, turned to Indian strikers, Aaren D'Silva and Joseph Sunny.

But neither of them has scored in over 883 minutes of play while starting as a CF or ST. With just nine goals in 21 games so far, the club is set to finish at the bottom of the

table this season.

Chennaiyin, however, gives a ray of hope for Indian forwards — Rahim Ali and Farukh Choudhary. They have honed their talent well under ISL League Winners Shield-winning manager, Owen Coyle.

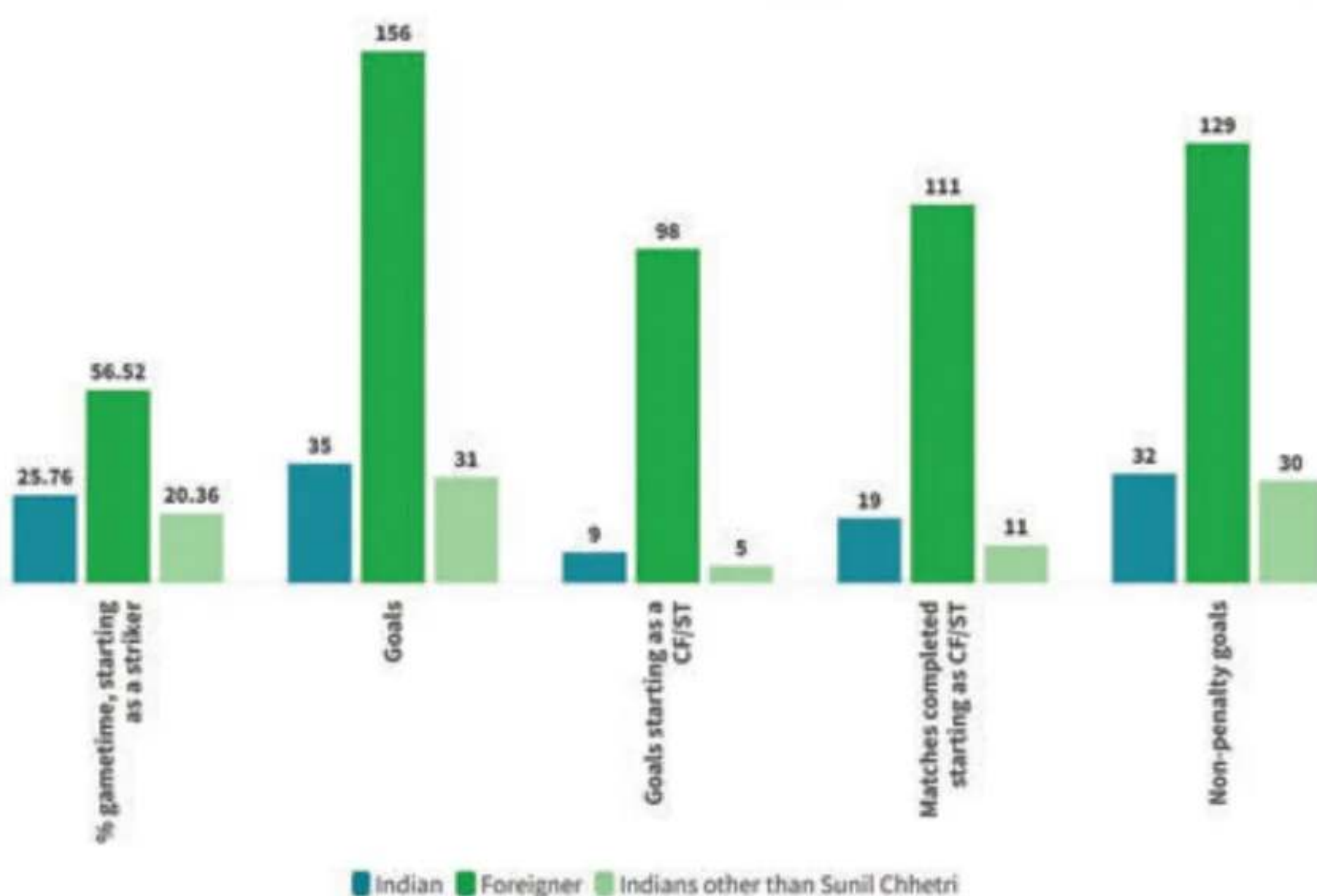
While Rahim led India's attack at the FIFA Under-17 World Cup in 2017, Farukh played primarily as a winger and an attacking midfielder under Coyle at his former club, Jamshedpur FC.

"It is understandable because if you are a coach, you put the better



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Goals and game-time for players playing as Strikers/Centre forwards



Source: FBREF, Opta • All data in the article is till the ISL match Odisha FC vs Punjab FC on April 2, 2024